

Phase 1: Business Definition

Task 1.1 – Writing the business description outline

COMP433 Software Engineering – Section 5

Semester 2 (Spring) 2025/2026

Hisham Ihshaish

Department of Computer Science, Birzeit University

Where we are now

Phase 0 closed; Phase 1 starts today

Phase 0

complete

Initiation

Group formation, business preferences, role allocation. Closed Sat 2 May 2026.

Phase 1

now

Business definition

Customer groups write a 1–2 page business description. Workshop with developer group on the deadline date.

Phase 2

to come

Requirements engineering

User requirements, system requirements, effort and cost estimation. All work in developer role.

Phase 3

to come

Analysis and modelling

Use case diagram, use case descriptions, activity diagram.

Phase 4

to come

System modelling and design

Class diagrams, sequence diagrams, design goals, architecture, components, deployment.

Why this phase exists

Software engineering starts before code

“Requirements engineering is the process of establishing the services that the customer requires from a system, and the constraints under which it operates and is developed.”

Sommerville (2016), Software Engineering 10th edition, Chapter 4

In plain language

You cannot design what you do not understand. Most failed software projects fail because the team built the wrong thing, not because they coded it badly.

Before requirements come the business and the people. What does the business actually do? Who uses it? What problems does it have today?

Phase 1 forces you to slow down and look at the business through the customer's eyes. Phase 2 onwards then turns that understanding into concrete requirements.

Two roles per group

Why every group is both customer and developer

Each group has a primary role as developer, and a secondary role as customer. The customer role is used only in Phase 1, Task 1.1. From Phase 2 onwards, every group works only on its own developer business.

How the cycle works

Developer role

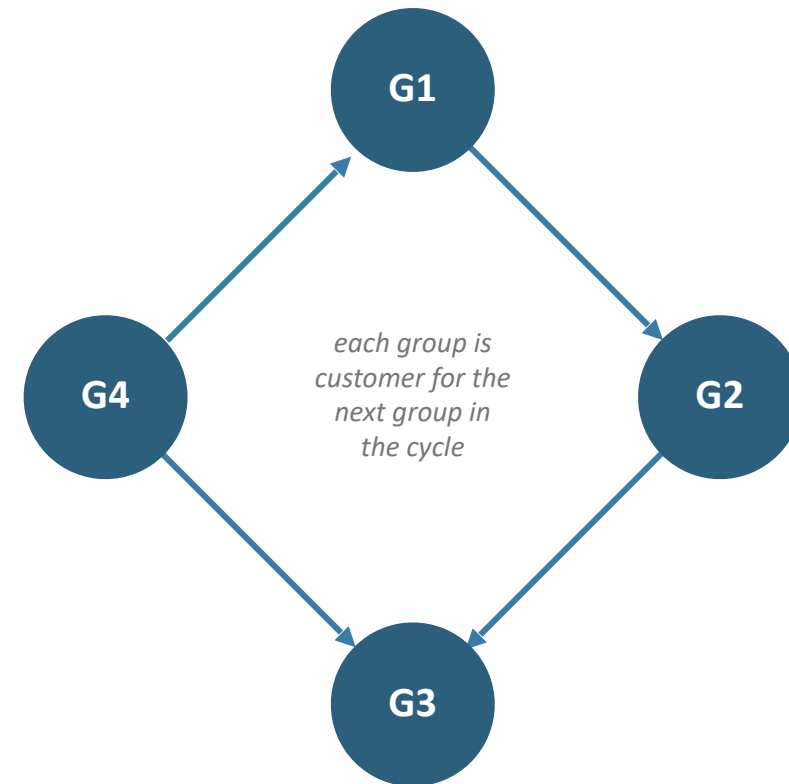
Your group develops your own allocated business across Phases 1 to 4. This is your primary role for the rest of the semester.

Customer role (Task 1.1 only)

Your group writes a business description for the developer group next to you in the cycle. After Phase 1 submission, the customer relationship ends – every group works only on its own business from Phase 2 onwards.

Find your pairing

See the Cycle Summary sheet in the attached spreadsheet – your customer-developer pairing is shown in one row.



What you produce in Task 1.1

A business description outline, one to two pages

What it IS

A description of an existing, real business in the chosen domain – written from the customer's perspective.

Specific, concrete, and grounded in real data: actual numbers, real services, real employees, real processes.

Written in business language, not technical language. A non-programmer should understand every sentence.

One to two pages: enough to be detailed; short enough to stay focused on what matters.

What it IS NOT

A description of the system you would like to build – that is Phase 2's job.

A list of user requirements or features. Phase 1 describes the business, not the software.

A marketing brochure or sales pitch. You are not selling the business; you are documenting it.

Vague or aspirational text. Avoid phrases like “the system will provide a smooth experience” – they say nothing.

A clear test: if a stranger reads your description, can they explain the business back to you correctly? If yes, it works. If they leave with questions, it does not.

The five questions

How to structure your business description

Use these five questions as your structure

Each maps to a section of your description

1

What is the business about?

What it is, what domain, what kind of customers it serves

2

What services does the business offer?

List each service explicitly: selling, delivery, payment, support, etc.

3

What is the business capacity?

Real numbers: monthly customers, products, employees, branches

4

How does the business work?

Business processes: a step-by-step flow for each service, the business model

5

Who works there and what do they do?

Employees and their roles, mapped to the services they support

The workshop

What happens on the deadline date

Monday 11 May 2026 in class (instead of 9th May)

The customer-developer interview workshop

Phase 1 ends with a workshop in class. Each customer group meets its developer group, hands over the written description, and is interviewed about it. Then they swap roles in the next pairing.

Before

Submit the written description electronically and bring a paper copy to the lecture. Mandatory paper copy.

Step 1

Customer presents the business description (5 minutes). Developer takes notes.

Step 2

Developer asks follow-up questions (10 minutes): clarifications, missing details, contradictions.

Step 3

Customer answers and notes points to revise (5 minutes).

After

Developer keeps the description as input for Phase 2. Customer's job ends here.

Groups that fail to bring a paper copy to the workshop will be marked down – the workshop cannot work without one.

Submission and timeline

Indicative – confirm with the announcement

Indicative timeline

From today

Phase 1 work begins. Use class time and group meetings.

Wed 6 May

Group L confirms its business choice. Unassigned students contact the instructor.

Fri 8 May

Latest sensible point to finish the draft. Allow time to read it back as a stranger.

Sat 9 May

Submission deadline. Workshop in class (will move to Monday 11th). Bring a paper copy.

After 9 May

Phase 2 begins. Customer/developer relationship dissolves; groups work on their own business.

What to submit

1

Cover page. Group letter, member names, IDs, and roles. Customer group → Developer group —> Business number/name.

2

Description. 1–2 pages, structured by the five questions. Plain prose with section headings.

3

PDF or Word. Submit electronically using the template provided in the announcement.

4

Paper copy. Bring one printed copy to the lecture on the deadline date for the workshop.

5

Email copy to developer. After submission, also send your developer group a copy by email.

Materials and resources

Where to find the supporting files

All materials for Phase 1 will be shared by the instructor. Use the placeholders below to record the actual links once they are posted on the course page.

Phase 1 announcement

The full announcement explaining the task, deadline, allocations, and group-specific notes.

Group allocations spreadsheet

Cycle Summary, Project Groups, Unassigned, and Project Timeline. Includes business catalogue 38–52.

Phase 1 description template

Structured Word template covering the five questions, with cover page formatting.

Five things to take away

If nothing else, remember these

1

You are describing an EXISTING BUSINESS in your customer role, not a future system. Present tense, real numbers, real people.

2

Use the five questions as your structure: what, services, capacity, processes, employees. Section headings help.

3

One business process per service, not one for the whole business. Map every employee role to the services they support.

4

Specificity is the difference between A and D. Concrete numbers, named services, explicit steps.

5

Submit by Saturday 9 May, bring a paper copy, and email a copy to your developer group.

References

Sommerville, I. (2016). Software Engineering, 10th edition, Chapter 4 (Requirements Engineering). Pearson. (R2)

Bruegge, B. and Dutoit, A. (2013). Object-Oriented Software Engineering Using UML, Patterns, and Java, 3rd edition, Chapter 4 (Requirements Elicitation). Prentice Hall. (R1)

Pressman, R. and Maxim, B. (2020). Software Engineering: A Practitioner's Approach, 9th edition, Chapter 8 (Understanding Requirements). McGraw-Hill. (R5)

IEEE Computer Society (2024). SWEBOK V4 – Knowledge Area: Software Requirements.

Boehm, B. (1981). Software Engineering Economics. Prentice Hall. – for the cost of late requirements changes.

COMP433 Project Structure and Tasks document (Phase 1 Task 1.1 specification).

Phase 1 announcement, Section 5 (Spring 2025/2026).

Anonymised Phase 1 submissions and marker annotations from previous semesters, used for the strong and weak examples.